AARON PETRINI PRESENTS

GuitarTools2

USER MANUAL

A practical guide to focused, mix-ready guitar tone.

WHAT IT DOES

GuitarTools2 combines tone-range filtering, low-end management, resonance and mud cleanup, color shelves, input/output gain, loudness matching, presets, and a scalable interface in one guitar-focused processor.

VERSION 2.0.0

MANUAL EDITION 01 / SEPTEMBER 2026

MONO AND STEREO AUDIO EFFECT

01 / START HERE

A focused first pass

Use the controls in this order when you want a fast, reliable starting point.

01 Set IN

Bring the incoming level to a sensible working point. Leave OUT at 0 dB for now.

02 Frame the range

Use LOW CUT to clear rumble and HIGH CUT to tame excessive top-end fizz.

03 Clean the problem

Switch on KILL RESO or CLEAR MUD only when the track needs them. Sweep their faders to find the issue.

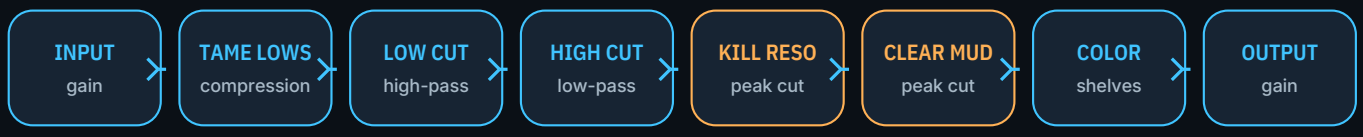
04 Add character

Use DEPTH for body and PRESENCE for bite. Select the MODE that targets the right area first.

05 Level-match

Enable MATCH before judging tonal changes. Then use the plugin BYPASS for an honest A/B check.

PROCESSING ORDER



02 / INTERFACE TOUR

Know your way around

The panel is organized into three tone zones, a central cleanup strip, and a compact control header.

TONE RANGE	CLEAN-UP	COLOR
Low Cut	Kill Reso	Depth
High Cut	Clear Mud	Presence
Aggression	Tame Lows	Mode

LEVELS: IN / MATCH / OUT

Header

Preset browser, save, undo, redo, Settings and global Bypass live across the top of the plug-in.

Settings

Open Settings to show or hide the tooltip strip, choose UI size, or open the Info panel.

Tooltip strip

When enabled, the lower strip shows a short description for the control under the pointer.

The AP logo or the Settings menu can open the Info panel. Bypass lets you compare the processed and dry signal without leaving the plug-in.

03 / TONE RANGE

Shape the boundaries

The cut filters set the usable bottom and top edge of the guitar before you fine-tune color or cleanup.

CONTROL	RANGE	AGGRESSION	USE IT FOR
LOW CUT	20 - 2500 Hz	12 / 24 / 36 / 48 dB/oct	Removing rumble, excess palm-mute weight, or room buildup.
HIGH CUT	1000 - 20000 Hz	12 / 24 / 36 / 48 dB/oct	Smoothing fizz, brittle amp tone, or too much pick edge.

LOW CUT: start gentle

Begin around 60 - 90 Hz for a full guitar tone. Raise it until the low end stops competing with bass and kick, then back off slightly if the track loses authority.

HIGH CUT: keep the useful bite

Start around 8 - 12 kHz when high-gain fizz is distracting. Use steeper slopes only when the unwanted top end needs a firmer boundary.

PRACTICAL RULE

Frequency chooses where the filter begins. AGGRESSION chooses how quickly it works past that point. Make the smallest change that solves the problem; the filters are most transparent when they are not doing more work than necessary.

A/B METHOD

1. Turn MATCH on. 2. Adjust one filter. 3. Toggle BYPASS. 4. Keep the move only if the guitar sits better, not just louder or darker.

04 / COLOR

Add body and bite

DEPTH is a low shelf. PRESENCE is a high shelf. Their MODE buttons choose a fixed focus frequency and contour before the gain control boosts or cuts it.

DEPTH

A low-shelf gain control for weight and body. Positive values add foundation; negative values reduce boom. Gain range: -15 to +15 dB.

PRESENCE

A high-shelf gain control for definition and bite. Positive values add clarity; negative values soften an aggressive edge. Gain range: -15 to +15 dB.

MODE FREQUENCY MAP

MODE	DEPTH FOCUS	PRESENCE FOCUS	LISTEN FOR
A	50 Hz	4.5 kHz	Lowest body or the first layer of edge.
B	80 Hz	6.25 kHz	Classic guitar weight and forward attack.
C	150 Hz	8 kHz	Low-mid body and a more open top.
D	275 Hz	12 kHz	Low-mid shape and the upper air region.

SUGGESTED METHOD

Pick the MODE that makes the control respond in the right area. Then make small gain moves, usually 0.5 - 2 dB at first. If a boost makes the guitar feel larger but less clear, try another MODE before adding more gain.

05 / CLEAN-UP

Solve the specific problem

The central strip is not a broad EQ section. Each control is designed to find and control a familiar guitar-mix issue.

CONTROL	RANGE	NORMAL / MODE	WHAT IT DOES
KILL RESO	2 - 9 kHz	-6 dB, Q 7 / -12 dB, Q 10	Cuts a focused harsh resonance. Sweep the fader to locate the problem, then choose MODE for a stronger, narrower cut.
CLEAR MUD	60 - 300 Hz	-4 dB, Q 0.7 / -8 dB, Q 0.7	Reduces low-mid buildup. Sweep toward the congested area; MODE doubles the cut depth.
TAME LOWS	0 - 100%	4:1, 20/30 ms / 8:1, 15/10 ms	Compresses the 70 - 220 Hz band to tighten low-end dynamics. MODE uses a faster, stronger response.

FIND, THEN REDUCE

Activate one cleanup tool, move its fader until the problem becomes obvious, then return to the smallest useful correction. If the issue is not clear, bypass the tool and move on.

USE MODE WITH INTENT

The MODE switch is a second, stronger character. It is useful for stubborn problems, but it can sound overdone quickly. Compare with MATCH on and BYPASS often.

06 / LEVELS AND COMPARISON

Gain-stage with confidence

IN and OUT let you place the guitar in the plug-in. MATCH helps you compare processing without being distracted by a level change.

IN

Input gain before the compressor and EQ chain. Range: -15 to +15 dB. Use it to set the level entering the processor.

MATCH

When enabled, the plug-in estimates an output offset from the dry and processed signals. This replaces the manual OUT setting while MATCH is active.

OUT

Output gain after processing. Range: -15 to +15 dB. Use it for final trim when MATCH is off.

AN HONEST A/B

1. Make your processing move. 2. Enable MATCH. 3. Toggle the global BYPASS. 4. Listen for tighter lows, less harshness, or better placement - not for a simple loudness jump. The processor crossfades the dry and processed signal on bypass changes for a smoother comparison.

Useful gain-staging habit

Keep IN and OUT near 0 dB while shaping the tone. If a preset needs a different level, use MATCH to evaluate it first, then choose the final OUT level deliberately for the session.

07 / PRESETS, SETTINGS, AND RECALL

Make the plug-in yours

Presets save the processor parameters. The plug-in also recalls its current preset name, UI scale, and tooltip visibility with the host session.

LOAD

Use the preset box in the header to choose root, factory, or user presets. GuitarTools2 opens on the Start From Here preset when it is available.

SAVE

Use the Save icon to write the current parameter state as an XML preset. User presets appear in the preset browser after saving.

UNDO / REDO

Step through recent parameter edits from the header. Use this while dialing in an idea instead of trying to reconstruct a lost move.

SETTINGS

Show or hide the tooltip strip, choose a 70%, 75%, 90%, 100%, 125%, 150%, or 200% UI size, or open Info.

BYPASS

Bypass all processing to compare the plug-in against the unprocessed track. Use it together with MATCH for a level-aware decision.

TWO USEFUL STARTING PRESETS

PRESET	ROLE
Start From Here	A practical opening state: 60 Hz Low Cut, 10.5 kHz High Cut, modest Color, KILL RESO and TAME LOWS active, and MATCH on.
Reset To Default	Returns the parameter layout to the plug-in defaults so you can rebuild a setting from a neutral state.

Tip: save a named version before making a big change. It is faster to compare two intentional states than to reverse-engineer a long chain of small edits.

08 / THREE FAST RECIPES

Starting points, not rules

Use these as a direction finder. Match the level, listen in the full arrangement, and adjust the smallest number of controls needed.

TIGHT RHYTHM

Low Cut around 80 - 120 Hz. High Cut around 8 - 11 kHz. Turn on TAME LOWS at a modest amount. Use KILL RESO only if upper-mid harshness remains.

BIG CLEAN

Keep the Low Cut lower, around 50 - 80 Hz. Use DEPTH MODE B or C with a small lift. Add PRESENCE sparingly if the part needs definition.

DENSE HIGH GAIN

Set High Cut first, often between 6 - 10 kHz. Sweep KILL RESO through 3 - 6 kHz for bite that hurts. Use CLEAR MUD if low mids crowd the bass and kick.

DECISION TREE

Too boomy? Start with Low Cut, then CLEAR MUD. Too harsh? Start with High Cut, then KILL RESO. Too thin? Try DEPTH. Too buried? Try PRESENCE. Too uneven in the lows? Try TAME LOWS. Always MATCH before deciding.

09 / CONTROL REFERENCE

Everything at a glance

This is the quick lookup page for the exposed processor controls and their operating ranges.

SECTION	CONTROL	RANGE / OPTIONS	ROLE
Tone Range	Low Cut	20 - 2500 Hz	High-pass boundary
Tone Range	High Cut	1000 - 20000 Hz	Low-pass boundary
Tone Range	Aggression	12 / 24 / 36 / 48 dB/oct	Cut filter slope
Color	Depth	-15 to +15 dB; A-D	Low shelf and focus mode
Color	Presence	-15 to +15 dB; A-D	High shelf and focus mode
Clean-up	Kill Reso	2 - 9 kHz; MODE	Focused resonance cut
Clean-up	Clear Mud	60 - 300 Hz; MODE	Low-mid buildup cut
Clean-up	Tame Lows	0 - 100%; MODE	70 - 220 Hz compression
Levels	IN / OUT	-15 to +15 dB	Input and final gain trim
Levels	MATCH	On / Off	Automatic output offset
Global	Bypass	On / Off	Dry / processed comparison

SYSTEM NOTES

GuitarTools2 is an AU, VST3, and Standalone audio effect with mono and stereo support. It does not require MIDI. The project reports no processing tail. Your host session stores plug-in state, including current preset name, UI size, and tooltip visibility.

10 / THE LAST TEN SECONDS

Trust your ears

The best GuitarTools2 setting is the one that leaves the guitar clearer, more controlled, and more useful in the record.

MATCH ON

You are not deciding because the processed signal is louder.

BYPASS CHECK

The move improves the part in context, not only in solo.

SMALL MOVES

Each control is doing a clear job; nothing is compensating for too much elsewhere.

SAVE IT

A useful setting becomes a repeatable starting point for the next session.

GUITARTOOLS2

Shape the guitar. Keep the music.

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